

5 Useful Flash Drive Tricks

File Mangement with Macintosh and Windows 7 & 8



Section One -- Introduction

Five Flash Drive Tricks

In this tutorial you will learn five techniques that will help you organize your flash drive.



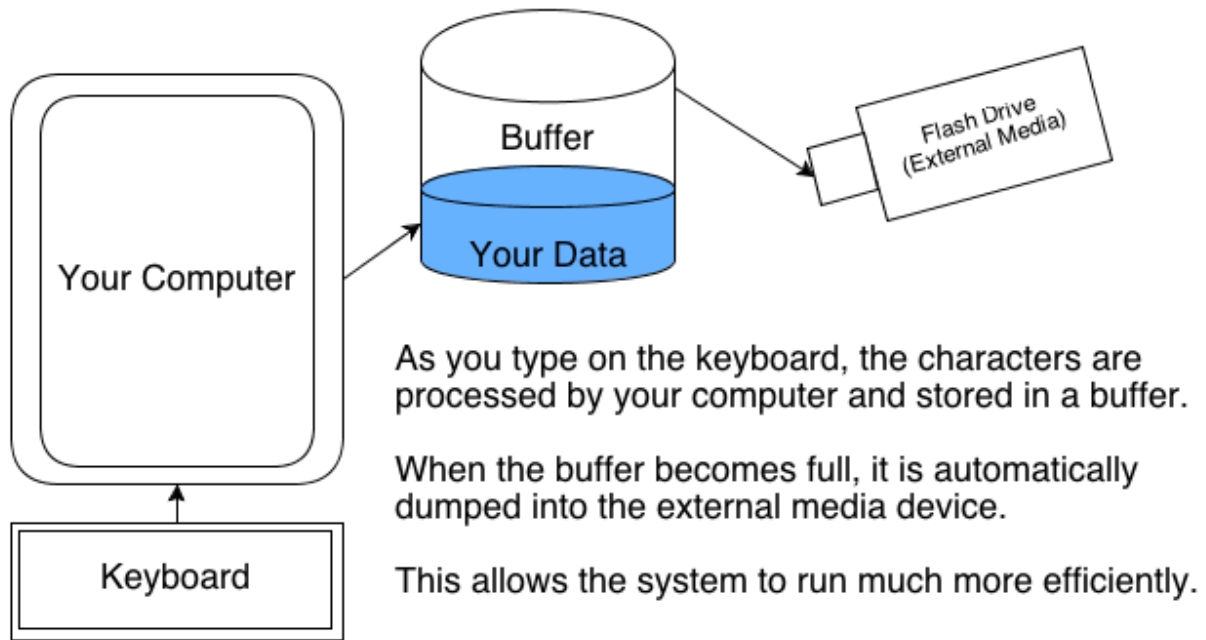
You will learn:

1. How to remove a flash drive without losing data
2. How to make new folders
3. How to make shortcut or alias icons.
4. Different ways to view your files and folders
5. How to reveal hidden file extensions

Section Two -- Remove a flash drive

A flash drive or any external hard-drive can be connected to your computer. To the operating system this is called "external media".

How a Memory Buffer Works



Instead of having the computer run back and forth between your computer and the external media every time you hit a key, a special memory area called a buffer is set up to hold incoming data. When the buffer reaches a certain level it is written to the flash drive all at once.

You normally don't notice the buffer working in the background. But, if you suddenly yank your flash drive out of its USB slot there may still be information sitting in the buffer that hasn't been transferred to your flash drive. The next time you go to read the file that part will be missing.

So, it is always a good habit to tell the computer to "dump the buffer" before you remove your flash drive or any other external media.

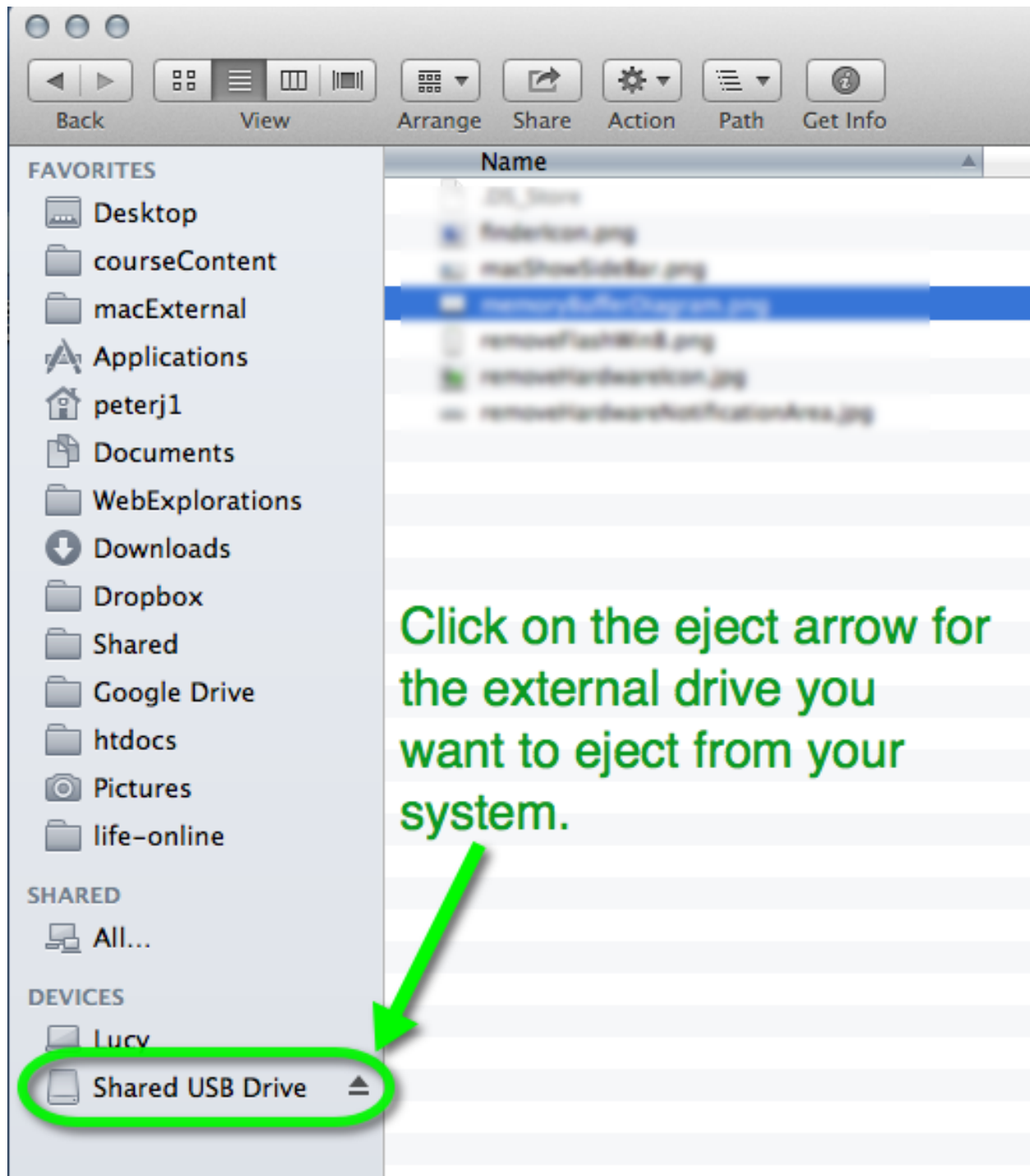
Here is how to do that on different systems.

Ejecting a Flash Drive on a Macintosh computer



On a Mac open up the Finder window.

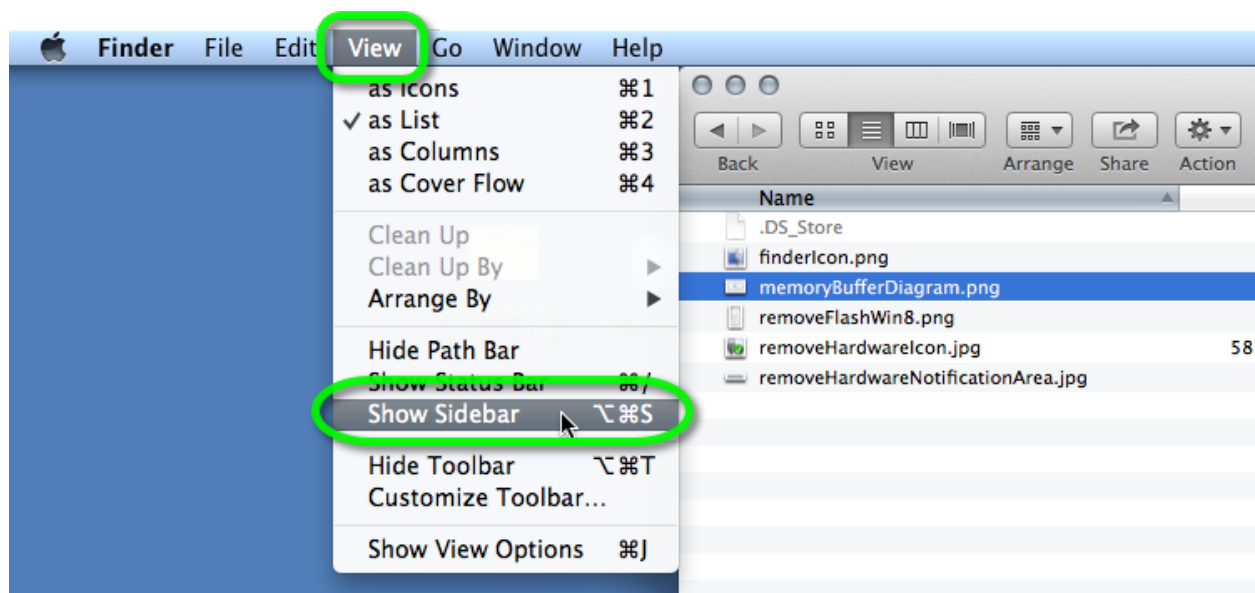
In the sidebar you should see a list of devices. Click on the eject arrow for your flash drive.



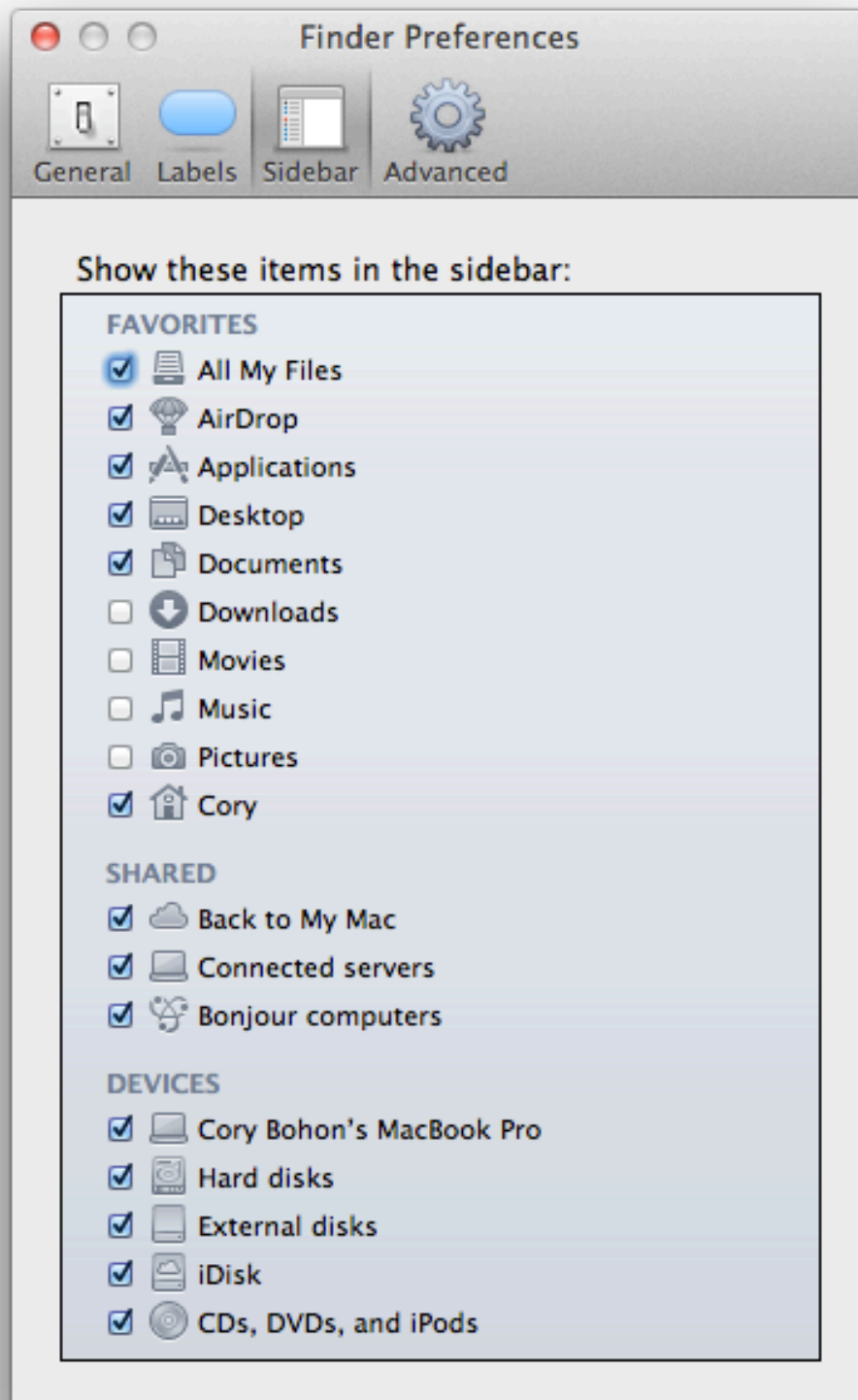
Here is a video showing how to disconnect a flash drive from a Mac.
http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IA1-DEDh_n4 Jump to minute 2:30 to see the ejection process.

Trouble Shooting

If the sidebar is not displaying, in the menu bar of Finder click on View/Show Sidebar.



If the list of devices is not showing, open up Finder/Preferences and click on the Sidebar tab and select the devices you want to be able to see. Here is an example:



Ejecting a Flash Drive in Windows 7

Windows 7 uses this icon to "Safely remove hardware and eject media": 



Look for it in the lower right hand corner of the screen. If you don't see this panel or this icon, look for the "Show hidden icons" arrow by mousing over the lower right corner of the screen. Click on the "Safely remove hardware and eject media" icon and wait for the message to display before removing your flash drive or external hard drive.

Here is a video showing how to disconnect a flash drive from Windows 7.
<http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=n3N5P8xos9Q>

Ejecting a Flash Drive in Windows 8

Starting from the Metro view of Windows 8 click on the "Desktop" box. From the desktop, you can either follow the same steps for Windows 7 listed above or you can:

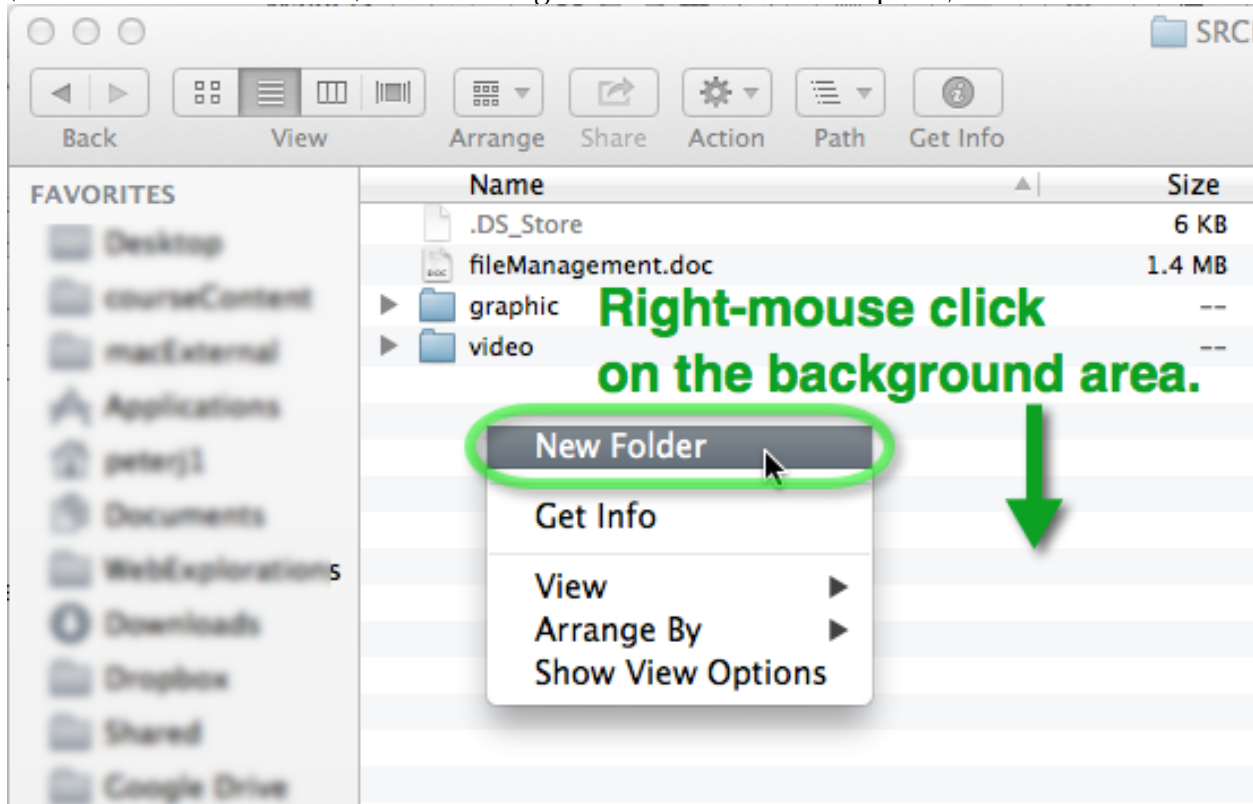
1. Click on the documents folder in the lower left corner.
2. Open up the "Computer" section on the far left column if it isn't already open.
3. You should see the name of your flash drive in the list.
4. Right-mouse click on the name of your flash drive and select "Eject"

Here is a video showing how to disconnect a flash drive from Windows 8.
<http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kkdm-kY3cZ4>

Section Three -- Make new folders

A directory and a folder are the same thing. These two terms are used interchangeably.

On all systems, once you are in the file management window simply right-mouse click (control-click on the Mac) on the background and choose the option, "New Folder"



This is a screen shot showing Finder - The Macintosh file system.

Opening up the File Manager on Various Systems

On a Macintosh the file manager is the Finder.



It is always open. Use COMMAND-TAB. As you hold down the COMMAND key, tap on the TAB until the Blue Smiling Face Finder icon is selected. Then release the COMMAND key.

On Windows 7 the file manager is Windows Explorer.



Click on the yellow folder in the lower left of the screen or right-mouse click on the Windows icon and select "Windows Explorer" from the drop-down list.

On Windows 8 Metro screen,

click on the Desktop box and then use the same instructions as Windows 7.

Tip #1:

Don't confuse Windows Explorer with Internet Explorer. Windows Explorer is used to view the files and folders on your system. Internet Explorer is a browser and is used to view web pages. Special thanks to the folks at Microsoft for making the names so similar and confusing.

In Windows 8 they changed the name to File Explorer. Basically the same program but a less confusing name.

Tip #2:

Folders contain files. They hold a collection of things. They do NOT have file extensions. Only files have extensions. The extension tells the system how to handle the file. For example: .ppt will automatically open up a PowerPoint file and .html will open up a web browser (whichever one is set up as the main one on your system.)

Section Four -- Make Shortcuts

The more you work with computers the more you'll find that there are a few folders and files that you access almost all the time.

If these are buried deep inside a folder structure it can be time consuming and tedious to navigate through a long list of folders inside of folders inside of folders (the path) to get to the files you want.

To save time, create a shortcut or alias on your desktop. It remembers where the actual file or folder is located on your system and will automatically jump to that location when you click on the shortcut.

To create a shortcut simply right-mouse click (control click on the Mac) on the file and select "Make Alias". Then click and drag the new alias to where it will be convenient to use. Most often this is one the desktop.

Each alias icon will have a small arrow in the lower left corner making it look slightly different the original icon that it is pointing to.



You can rename the shortcut/alias to anything you want.

Simply right-mouse click on the shortcut (command click on the Mac) and select "Rename".

You can also safely delete a shortcut.

It is only a pointer to the actual file or folder so you are only deleting the shortcut and not the actual file or folder.

Shortcuts to a Flash Drive

It may sound silly, but remember, if you make a shortcut to files on your flash drive then the flash drive must be connected to your computer so the system can find those files.

Here is a video showing how to make shortcuts on a Macintosh

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UOe-gWR-35g>

Here is a video showing how to make shortcuts on Windows.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mrjAtC8iiA>

For Windows 8 Metro view, click on the "Desktop" square to get to the File Manager icon.



Section Five -- Different Views of Your Files and Folders

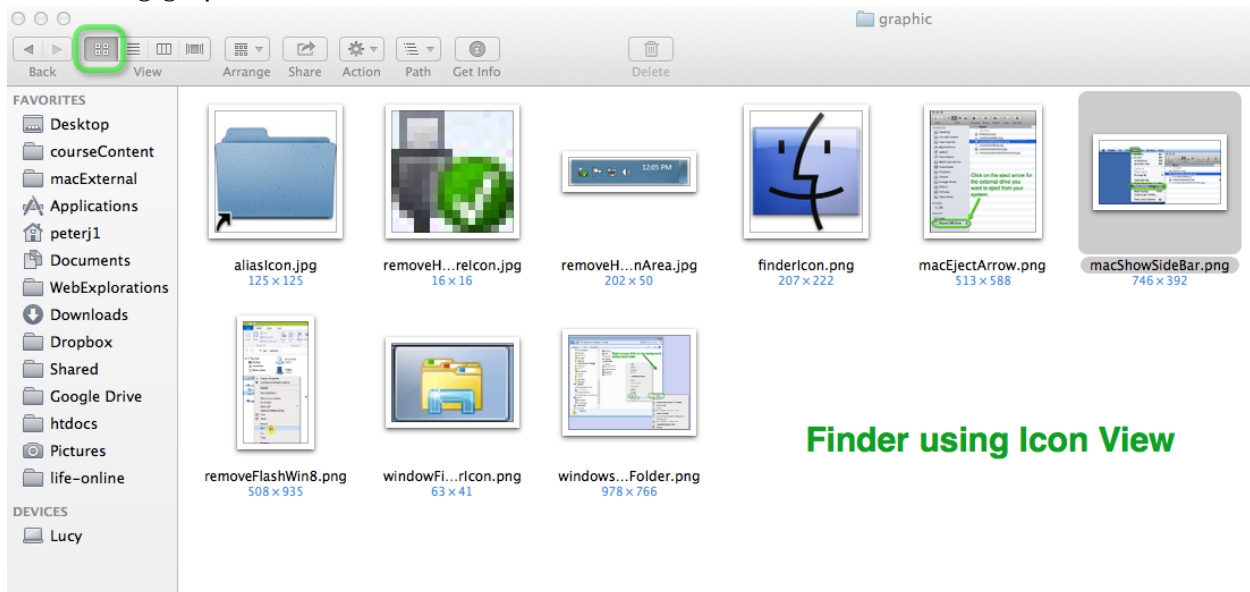
You can change the view on Windows Explorer and Finder.

For example, if you are looking at a folder of image files you'll probably want to view them as thumbnail images. If you are dealing with text files you can show the file names in a list. Or, if you need to know which file is newest you can look at the detailed version.

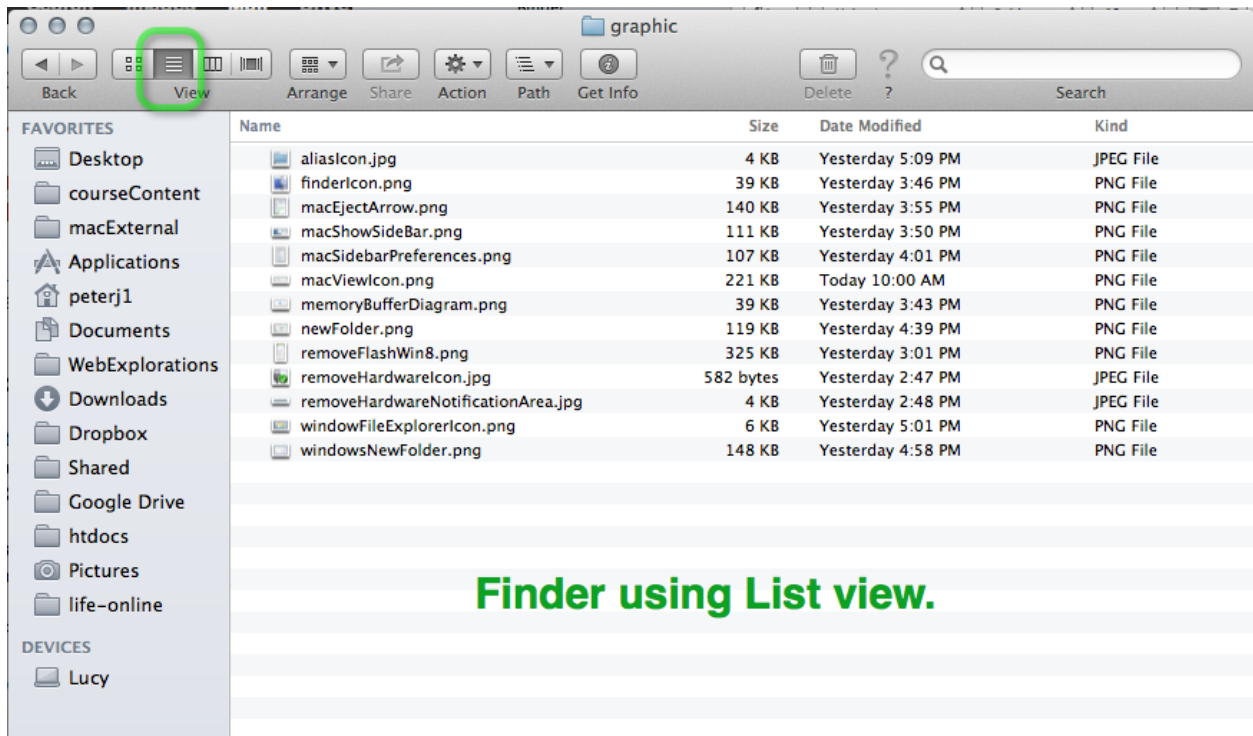
Here's how the different views look in the Macintosh Finder program.

To change the view in Finder click on the View button in the upper left corner of the Finder window.

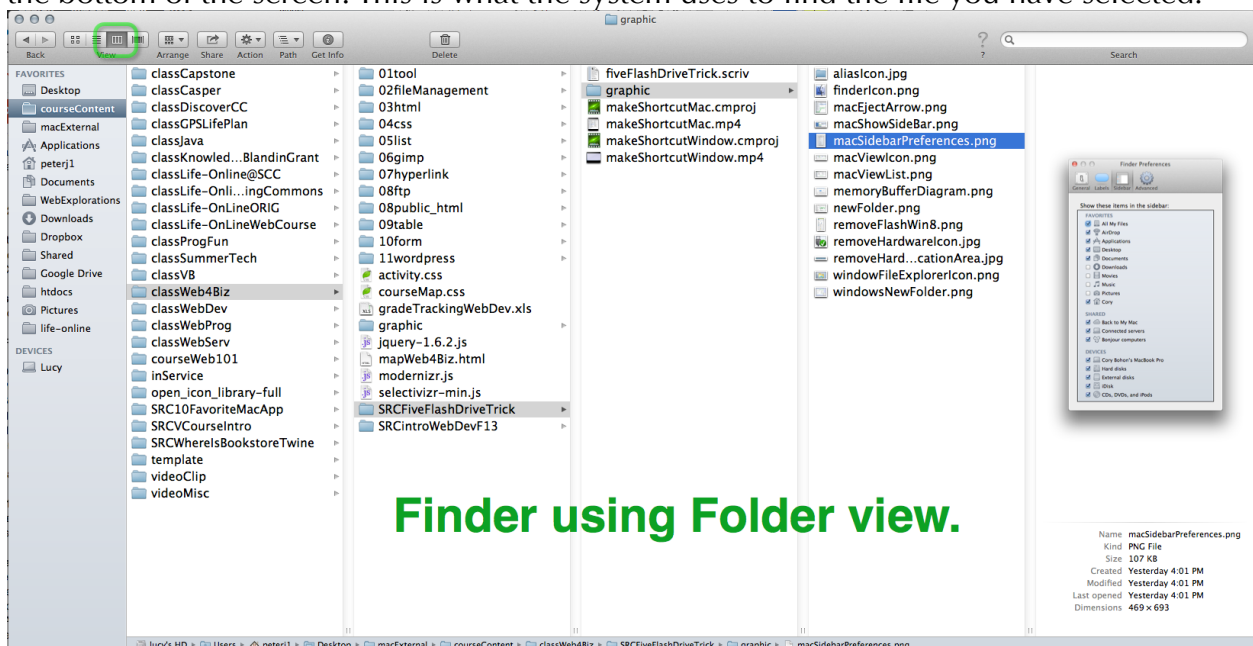
Here is the icon view, showing all the files using their icons. This is great for folders containing graphics.



Here is the list view, showing the details of all the files in a particular folder. This is useful when you need to find something by date or need to know how big the file is or what kind of file it is. Double click on the column headings to sort on that column.



Here is the folder view. This gives a better view of where a file is located in all the subfolders. Use this view when you need to move files around from one folder to the next. Or when you are working with a folder that has lots of sub-folders Notice the "path" along the bottom of the screen. This is what the system uses to find the file you have selected.

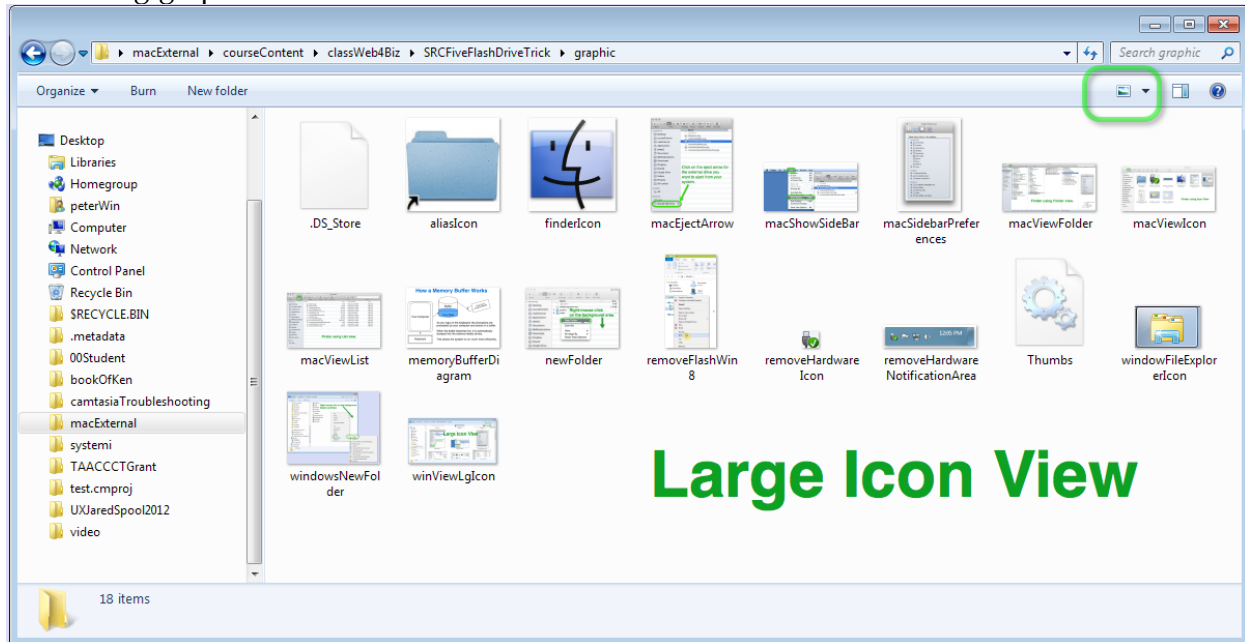


Here's how the different views look in the Windows Explorer.

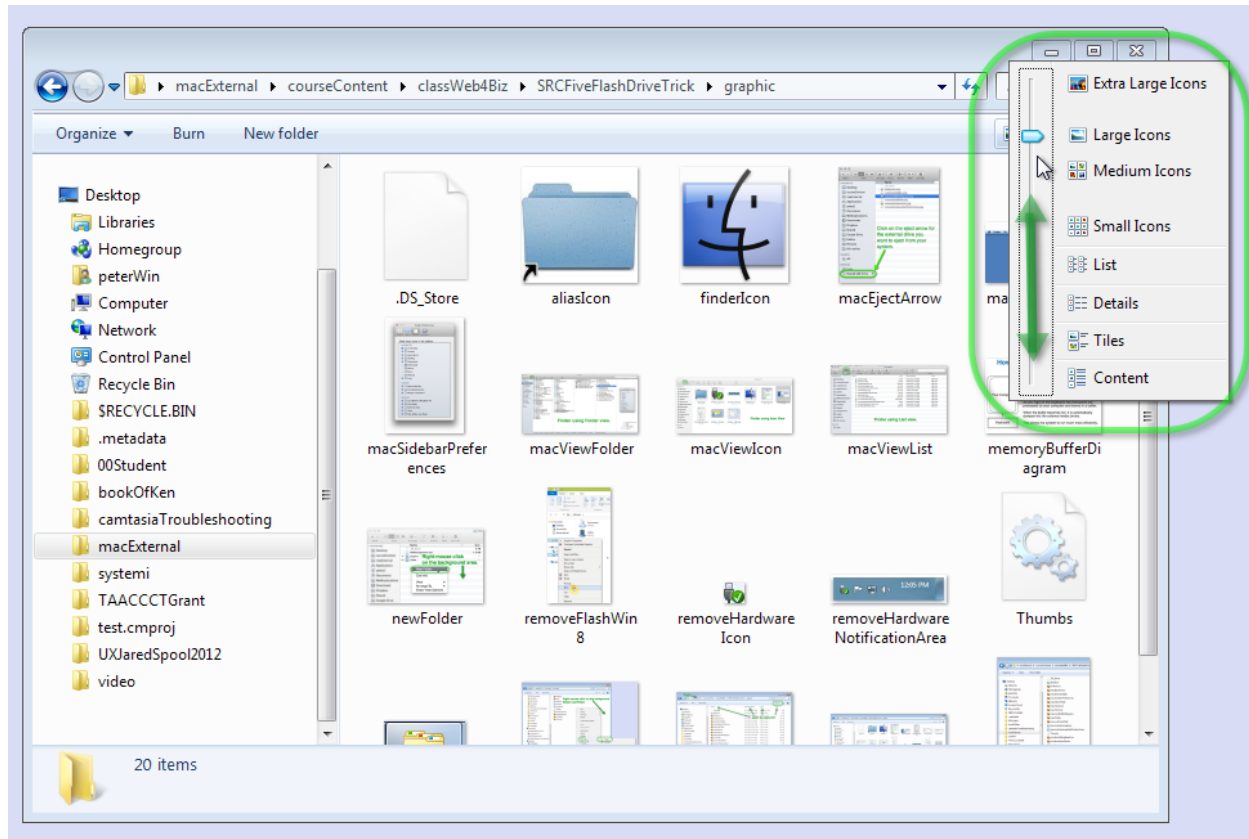
To change the view in File Explorer click on the Option button in the upper right corner of

the Explorer window.

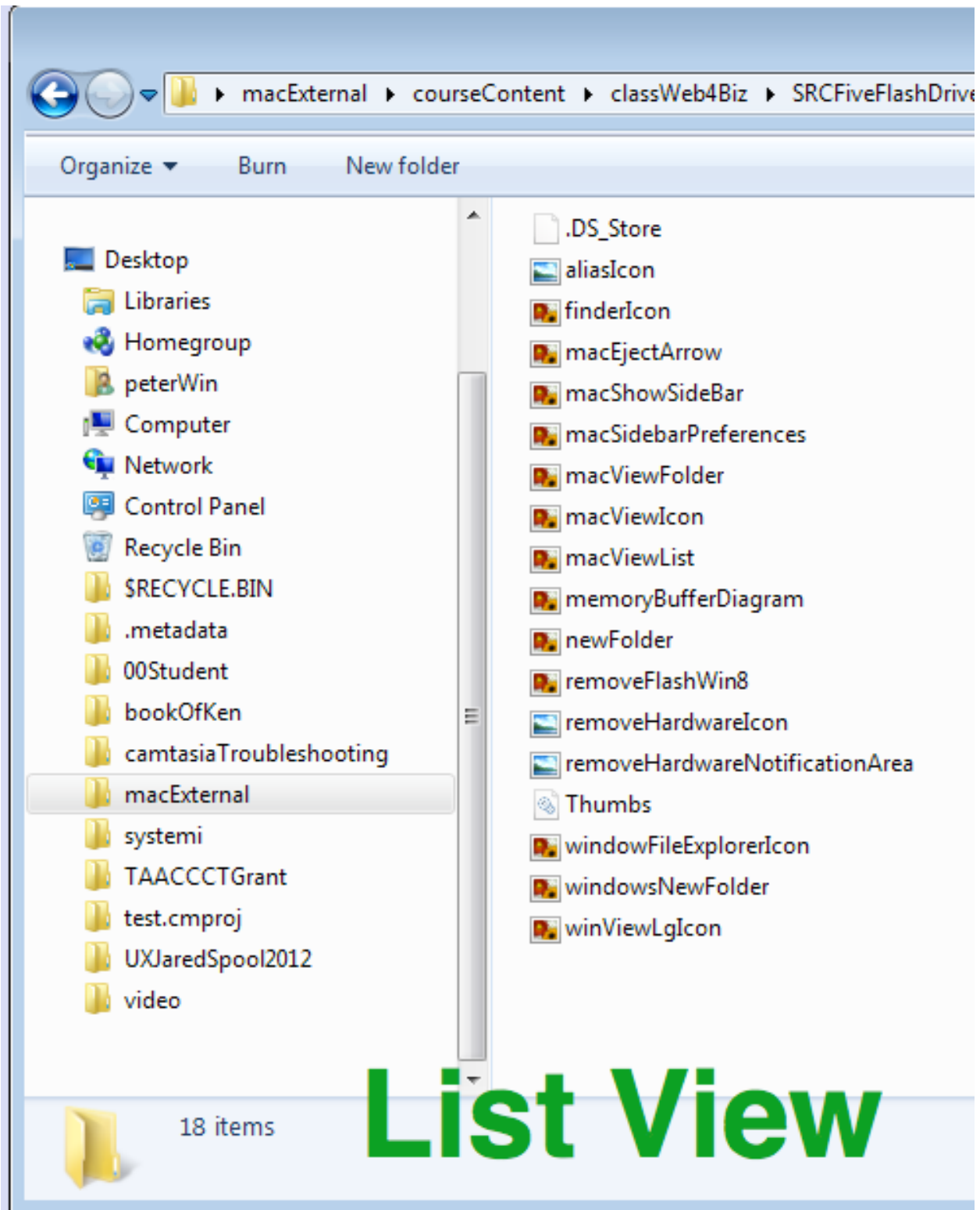
Here is the icon view, showing all the files using their icons. This is great for folders containing graphics.



Notice when you choose a view you can also use the slider to determine how large the icons will be.

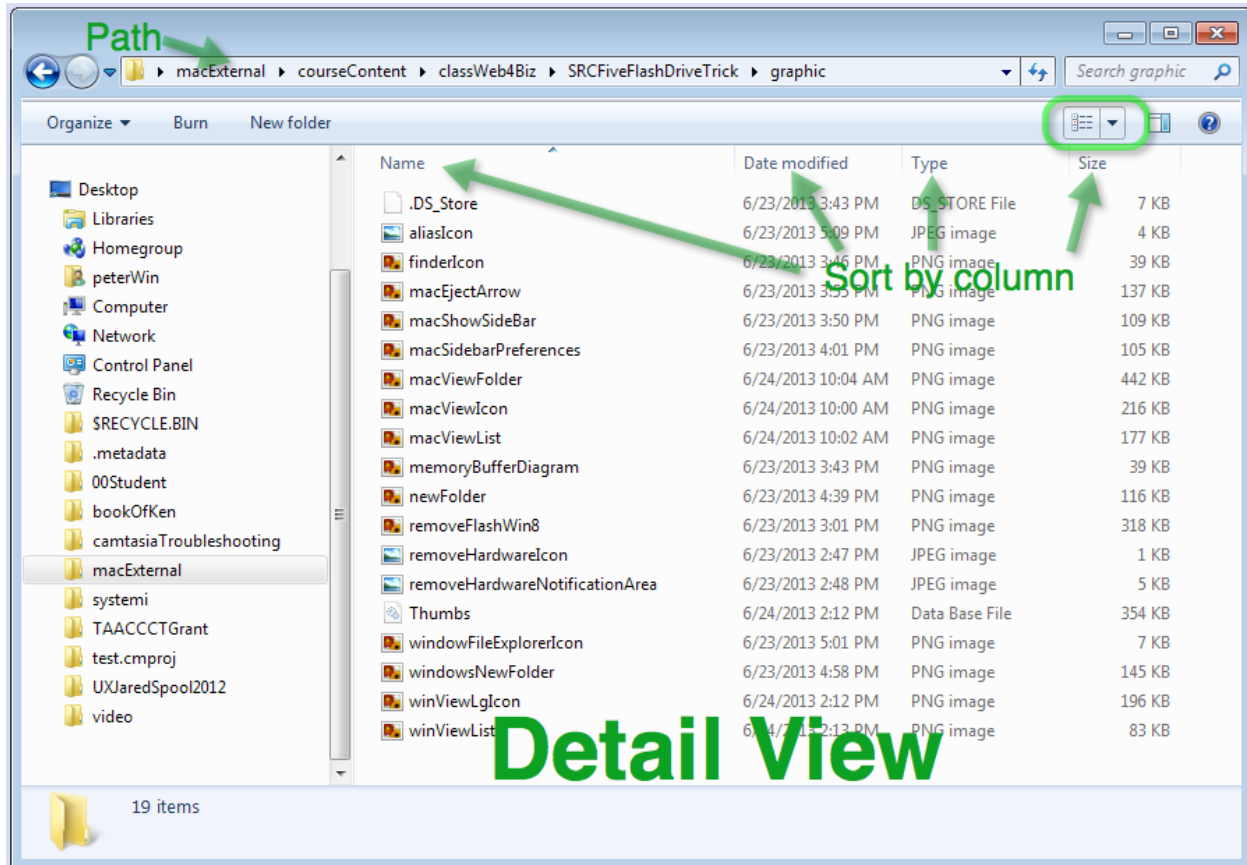


Here is the list view, showing just the file names. This is useful when you want to find something quickly and want to see as many filenames as possible on the screen.



This is the Detailed View which includes the filename, date/time stamp, file type, and size. Use this view when you want to find a file by creation date or rank all the files by size. Simply double-click on the column titles to sort the view by that criteria.

Along the top of each of the views you will also see the path to that particular file. You can also click anywhere on this path to jump to another folder. Or, you can click on the small black triangles to see a list of subfolders you can jump into.



Section Six -- Reveal The Hidden File Extensions

The file extensions should automatically display on your Mac computer. However, if they aren't here is how to turn them on.

- 1) Open up a Finder window.
- 2) Select Finder/Preferences from the menu.
- 3) Click on the Advanced tab.
- 4) Check the box "Show all filename extensions"



Reveal the Hidden File Extensions in Windows (7 and 8)

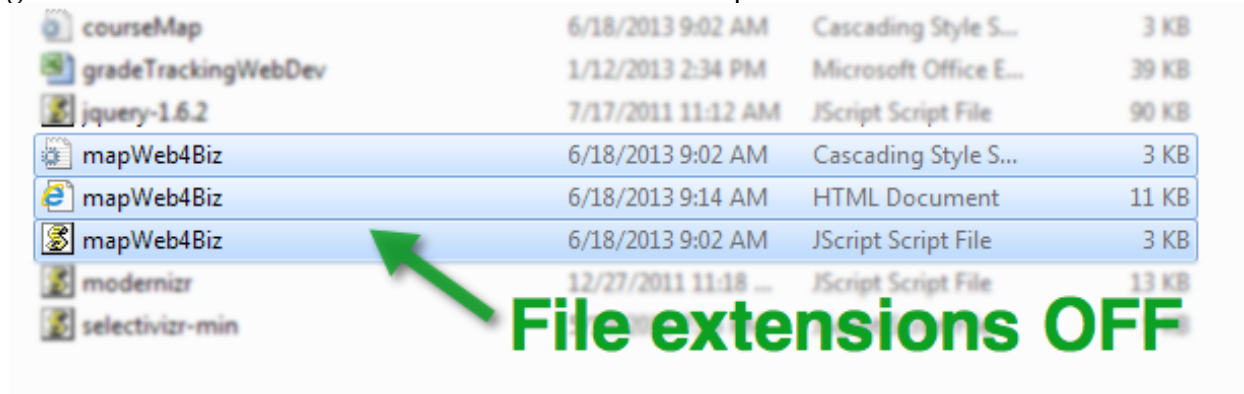
File extensions are used to tell your computer how to handle a file.

For example, your computer can be set up so that every file ending with .doc will automatically open up in Word (when you double-click on the icon or file name in File Explorer).

Windows purposely hides these file extensions from you to simplify things. But, this can be troublesome because often a set of files will have the same name and the only thing that is different is the file extension.

Here is what File Explorer displays by default - NO FILE EXTENSIONS!

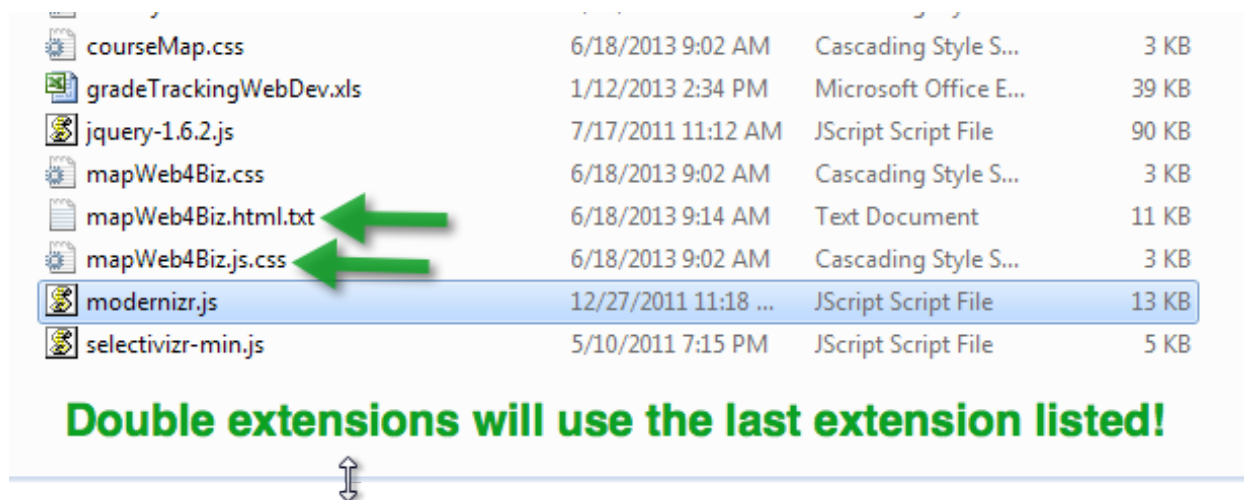
You can look over in the third column to see what type of file each one is but at first glance it looks like there are three files all named mapWeb4Biz.



courseMap	6/18/2013 9:02 AM	Cascading Style S...	3 KB
gradeTrackingWebDev	1/12/2013 2:34 PM	Microsoft Office E...	39 KB
jquery-1.6.2	7/17/2011 11:12 AM	JScript Script File	90 KB
mapWeb4Biz	6/18/2013 9:02 AM	Cascading Style S...	3 KB
mapWeb4Biz	6/18/2013 9:14 AM	HTML Document	11 KB
mapWeb4Biz	6/18/2013 9:02 AM	JScript Script File	3 KB
modernizr	12/27/2011 11:18 ...	JScript Script File	13 KB
selectivizr-min			

File extensions OFF

And, if you rename any of these files you will end up with a hidden extension, even if you want a different one. Here is an example where a student renamed a file to .html. The .txt extension was hidden so he ended up with mapWeb4Biz.html.txt. The computer uses the last extension so this was treated like a .txt or text file.



courseMap.css	6/18/2013 9:02 AM	Cascading Style S...	3 KB
gradeTrackingWebDev.xls	1/12/2013 2:34 PM	Microsoft Office E...	39 KB
jquery-1.6.2.js	7/17/2011 11:12 AM	JScript Script File	90 KB
mapWeb4Biz.css	6/18/2013 9:02 AM	Cascading Style S...	3 KB
mapWeb4Biz.html.txt	6/18/2013 9:14 AM	Text Document	11 KB
mapWeb4Biz.js.css	6/18/2013 9:02 AM	Cascading Style S...	3 KB
modernizr.js	12/27/2011 11:18 ...	JScript Script File	13 KB
selectivizr-min.js	5/10/2011 7:15 PM	JScript Script File	5 KB

Double extensions will use the last extension listed!

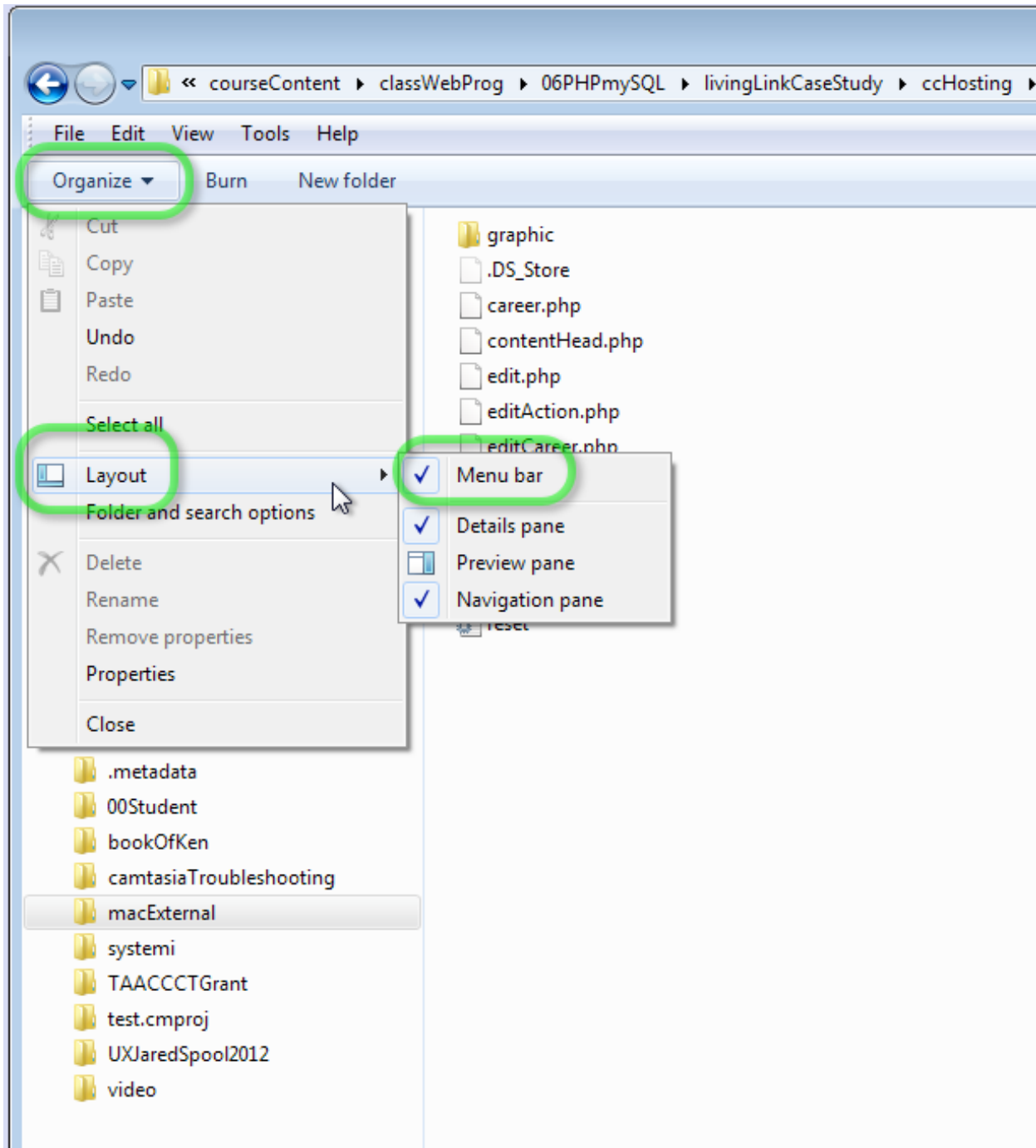
If file extensions are OFF, you will not know what the actual extension really is...

Turn on File Extensions

First, display the menu options for File Explorer.

In File Explorer click on Organize/Layout/Menu bar.

This will turn on the File -- Edit -- View --- Tools -- Help menu,



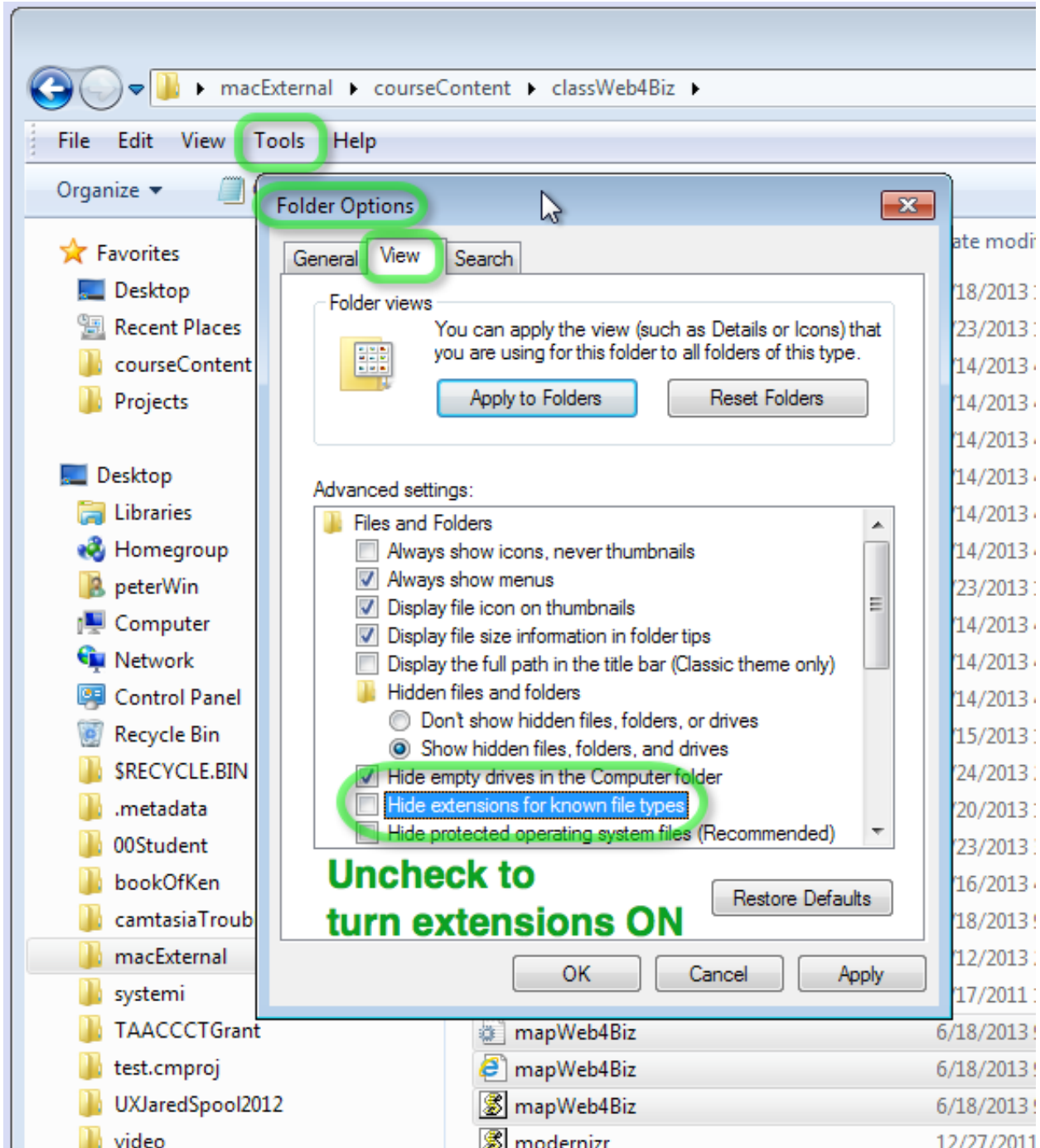
Next, turn off the option to hide file extensions.

Using the menu select Tools/Folder Options.

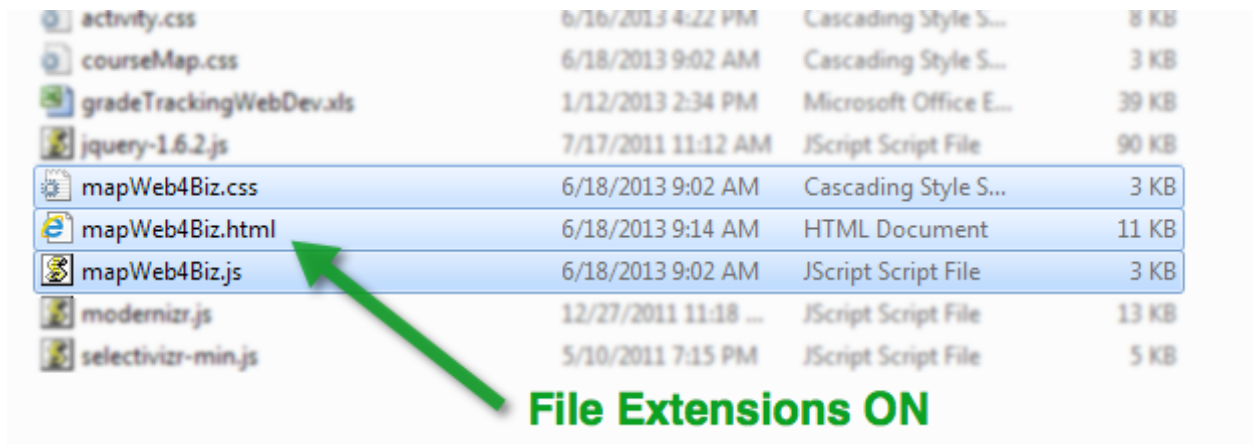
In the Folder Options window select the View tab.

Look for the item "Hide extensions for known file types" and uncheck that box.

Click on OK.



This will set up your system so it always shows the file extensions keeping you in control of your system.



activity.css	6/16/2013 4:22 PM	Cascading Style S...	8 KB
courseMap.css	6/18/2013 9:02 AM	Cascading Style S...	3 KB
gradeTrackingWebDev.xls	1/12/2013 2:34 PM	Microsoft Office E...	39 KB
jquery-1.6.2.js	7/17/2011 11:12 AM	JScript Script File	90 KB
mapWeb4Biz.css	6/18/2013 9:02 AM	Cascading Style S...	3 KB
mapWeb4Biz.html	6/18/2013 9:14 AM	HTML Document	11 KB
mapWeb4Biz.js	6/18/2013 9:02 AM	JScript Script File	3 KB
modernizr.js	12/27/2011 11:18 ...	JScript Script File	13 KB
selectivizr-min.js	5/10/2011 7:15 PM	JScript Script File	5 KB

File Extensions ON

Important Tip:

Note that folders do NOT have file extensions. They are only there to help keep all your files organized in groups.

Files have extensions so the computer knows what program to use to run the file. The computer system already knows that folders are just there to keep things organized. So it doesn't need an extension to tell it what to do with a folder.

Folders don't do anything. Files do.

If you put extensions on folders your brain will think that they are files. It can get very confusing!

Section Seven -- Summary

What have you learned?

You now know several techniques that will help you organize the files and folders on your computers and flash drives.

1. How to remove a flash drive without losing data
2. How to make new folders
3. How to make shortcut or alias icons.
4. Different ways to view your files and folders
5. How to reveal hidden file extensions



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June 2013

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